decision. He was a thorough gentleman and a professional all his life. This was the first time I was serving under him.

Another major challenge I faced was to save the division from being pushed out from Meerut to Tibri, a small military station near Gurdaspur. For various reasons, both operational and administrative, it made little sense to cause so much of turbulence and expenditure. I earnestly appealed to everyone who mattered and was eventually successful in getting the decision put on hold and subsequently, reversed. There were some amongst the military brass who did not give a damn if there wasn't enough accommodation for married officers and men or schooling facilities in Tibri. The affect on the morale of soldiers was given short shrift. The relocation would have been perfectly understandable if there was a war in the offing. In hindsight, with the revised operational role which was also initiated by me, it was a prudent decision to abort the move.

The next year, we were asked to conduct a seminar on 'heavy breakthrough', a Russian concept. Since this involved large-scale employment of armour, mechanized forces and artillery, it should have been ideally conducted by the Strike Corps. For inexplicable reasons, the responsibility was given to our formation. Anyway, as is my wont, I took it up as a challenge. To begin with, we analysed the term 'heavy breakthrough', and tried to understand the fundamental issues involved in such an operation. We got eminent speakers to air their views and interact with the audience. Various scenarios on how to execute a heavy breathrough in our context were discussed. In my mind it was clear that this concept involved the delivering of a sledgehammer blow with mechanized forces at a given point to achieve a breakthrough. Having done that, we would need to continue the momentum by penetrating into the bowels of the enemy's defenses and turn the flanks. It became evident that the three stages of the battle, 'the break-in, dogfight and break-out', ought to be merged into a seamless operation and taken to its logical conclusion. The chief of army staff, General Shankar Roychowdhury, the army commander, Lieutenant General H.B. Kala, the corps commander and division commanders and high-ranking